

KEY BATTLE

SALAMIS

480BCE

During the second Persian invasion of Greece, Athenian admiral Themistocles tricked Xerxes's Persian flotilla – three times the size of Themistocles' force of 378 triremes – into entering the Straits of Salamis. In the narrow waterway, the Persian force could not exercise its numerical advantage, and was badly mauled by the Greek ships.



▲ The Greek navy triumphed at Salamis through ingenious use of the terrain and waterways.

KEY DEVELOPMENT

HOPLITES AND PHALANXES

Around 700BCE, a new type of foot soldier emerged in Greece. The hoplite, equipped with a long spear, a sword, an elaborate bronze corselet and helmet, and a large wooden shield (*aspis*, or *hoplon*), would form the backbone of Greek armies for the next 500 years.

The earliest examples of hoplite equipment date back to about 710BCE, and within half a century of this date, depictions on vases show hoplites fighting in their signature tactical formation – the phalanx. Composed of rows of spear-wielding hoplites, the phalanx was normally eight men deep. With spears of around 240–70cm (95–105in) in length, only the first three ranks could reach the enemy line, but the phalanx's structure presented a fearsome barrier.

THE AGE OF THE HOPLITE

In the 7th and 6th centuries BCE, the main hoplite tactic involved colliding with the opposing phalanx, followed by concerted pushing and stabbing. There was little tactical sophistication, and the encounters continued until one side broke and fled. Only the hoplite's left side was fully protected, thanks to the *hoplon* (shield) of the man next to him: as a result, the phalanx tended to drift to the right, as each man tried to edge behind the *hoplon* of his neighbour.

By the early 5th century, bronze corselets had been superseded by linen or scale leather armour, allowing the wearer more freedom of movement. When Darius of Persia invaded Greece in 490BCE, the lightly armed Greek phalanx charged the Persian archers at Marathon, neutralizing one of their opponents' key advantages, and aiding an unlikely Greek victory against significant odds. Eleven years later, at Plataea, a renewed Persian invasion was defeated by the hoplites of Sparta, a militarized Greek city-state that trained its warriors from childhood. Sparta's rival, Athens, also participated in the land campaign against the Persians, but its most valuable contribution was a fleet of triremes – fast ships powered by triple banks of oarsmen – that outmanoeuvred the Persians to victory at Salamis, in 480BCE.

With the Persians defeated, Sparta and Athens clashed for almost the next 80 years, resulting in the Peloponnesian War (431–404BCE), which, though bloody, showed only a few innovations in equipment and tactics. The armies began to make more use of archers, and employed flexible light infantry, called peltasts, as skirmishers, armed with

► ALEXANDER THE GREAT

Alexander's tactical brilliance enabled him to defeat superior forces, which in turn allowed him to conquer the Persian empire within three years.

